

Variation in learner writing and a comparison with textbook models

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2 Method

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- ELT coursebook dimensions
- Additive analysis of ICLE on coursebooks

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Disclaimer: Ongoing work. . .

This is work in progress.

Goals

- ① Textbooks play a significant role in the learning process and are widely adopted worldwide. However, there is limited corpus evidence on how the text models presented in textbooks impact learners' writing.
- ② The first major goal is to develop a dimensional model that characterizes the major linguistic features found in English Language Teaching (ELT) textbooks.
- ③ The second major goal is to assess the presence of these dimensional characteristics in student writing and identify the dimensions that are most and least reflected in their texts.

Influence of textbooks on teachers and learners

(Richards, 2014, p.19)

[...] **[C]oursebooks are the main teaching resource used by many of the world's English teachers.** The extent of English teaching worldwide could probably not be sustained without the support of the many different kinds of textbooks (...) Tomlinson (2003). In many schools textbooks provide the main basis for the curriculum (Richards, 1993)). (Appel, 2011, pp.50-51) comments: '**In no other school subject do coursebooks exert a similar influence as in language teaching.** The book is in fact often treated as the syllabus.'

(Dockx, Bellens, & De Fraine, 2020, p.1)

Textbooks are often thought to guide the teacher's daily practice and to provide the main teaching material that students experience (Harwood, 2017; Mullis, Martin, Foy, & Arora, 2012; Schmidt, McKnight, & Raizen, 1997). Accordingly, **textbooks are expected to affect students' learning progress** (Törnroos, 2005).

(Dockx et al., 2020, p.3)

In Sweden, Johansson (2006) (...) found that **textbooks guide which content is presented to students.** Lepik, Grevholm, and Viholainen (2015) (...) found that between 49 and 64% of the teachers prepare their lessons based on a textbook.

Methods

Methods

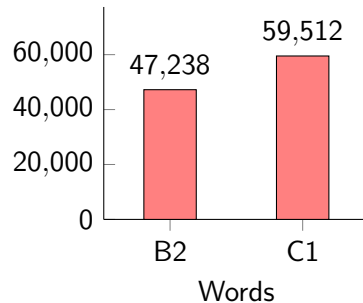
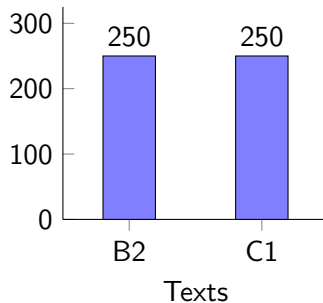
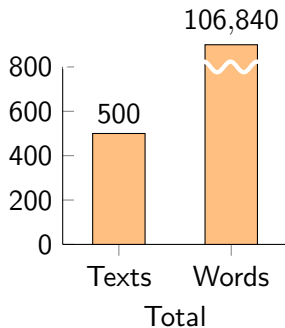
ELTT Corpus design

Criterion	Details
Population	English Language Teaching (EFL) textbooks / coursebooks for classroom use ¹ Proficiency exam preparation textbooks for classroom use ²
Sampling frame	Major publishers and websites
Sources	43 different sources: 91% print (N=39), 9% online (N=4)
Authorship	A range of the major ELT authors
Market	Global reach, international market
Age target	Young adults, adults
Approach	Communicative, task-based, prescriptive, school-centered, some corpus-informed
Variety	British English, General English
Time span	25 years (1996–2021)
Registers	19
Sample size	500 texts, 106,840 words (213.7 words on average)
Balance	For proficiency levels: 50% B2, 50% C1

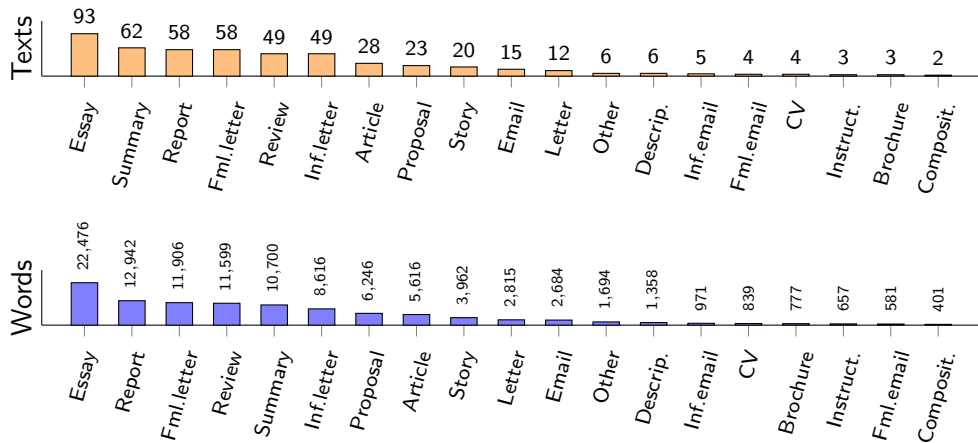
¹ e.g. *Aspire Upper Intermediate*, Cengage ; *Clockwise Upper Intermediate Classbook*, OUP

² e.g. *Cambridge Certificate in Advanced Eng.*, CUP; *Straightforward Upper Int.*, Macmillan

ELTT Corpus size

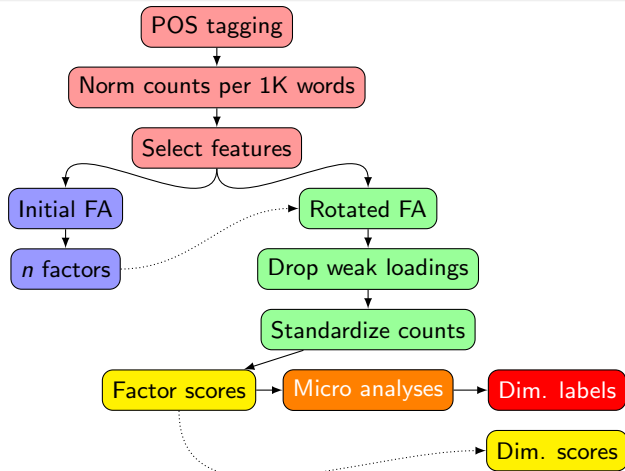


ELTT Corpus size by register



Full MD Analysis

Biber (1988, 1995), Berber Sardinha and Veirano Pinto (2014, 2019)



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Findings

Novel MD Analysis of ELT coursebooks

Dim. 1

Dimension 1

Factor Pattern: Dimension 1

Persuasion, speaker engagement, and personal opinion vs Expression of analysis and technical information

Positive Features	Loading
Sum stance adverbs	.57962
Emphatics	.52316
Contraction	.50323
First person pronoun / possessive	.45759
(Verb (not including auxiliary verbs)	.45175)
Pronoun it	.42205
Place adverbials	.38777
(that deletion	.38573)
(Second person pronoun / possessive	.33459)

Negative Features	Loading
Nominalization	-.57626
Word length	-.57618
Preposition	-.50109
Abstract/process nouns	-.42603

Mean Dim. 1 Scores

Persuasion, speaker engagement, and personal opinion vs Expression of analysis and technical information

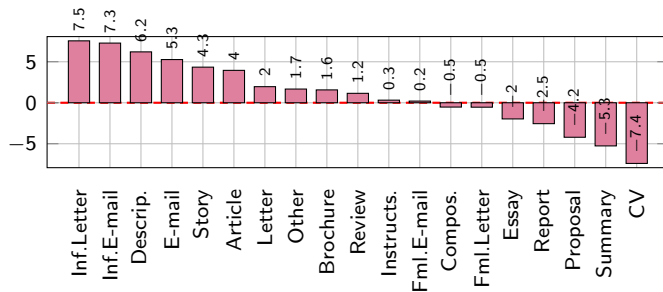


Figure: $R^2=.494773$ (49.48%), $F=26.17$, $p<.0001$

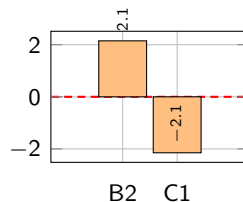


Figure: $R^2=.147255$ (14.73%), $F=86.00$, $p<.0001$

Dim.1 pos

Persuasion, speaker engagement, and personal opinion

C1, Informal Letter, score=6.49

Hi Matt, Time for a catch-up! I've **got** some exciting news; I've **put my** fears to one side and **made up my** mind to **do** what **you did** a year ago and **go** backpacking around Europe. Nice, eh? But I'm **hoping** I can **count** on **your** support, buddy, because I've **got** a ton of questions. First off, what about the route – should I **plan it** all **out** in advance or **just go** with the flow and **see** where **my** journey **takes me**? What did **you do**? I **think maybe** some advance planning **is** a good idea (...)

- Stn.adv.: maybe
- Emphatic: just
- Pers.prn.1st: I, me, my
- Verb (non-aux.): count, do, go, got, hoping, is, made, plan, put, see, takes, think

- It: it
- That del.: hoping..., think...
- Pers.prn.2nd: you, your

Dim.1 neg

Expression of analysis and technical information

B2, Proposal, score=-5.19

Introduction. The purpose **of** this report is to make recommendations **on** ways to improve the student facilities **on** the **university** campus. I have recently completed a post-graduate degree course at the **university** and overall was very satisfied **with** the **experience**. The **university** campus is large and attractive, and it provides excellent libraries, lecture halls and IT **services**. However, some **of** its student facilities could be greatly improved, as outlined below. Restaurants and caf s. First **of** all, there are not enough restaurants **on** the campus offering cheap, healthy food. Prices are very high **in** most places, and the **majority of** (...)

- Nominaliz.: Introduction, experience, majority, university
- Word length: Introduction, recommendations, post-graduate

- Prep.: in, of, on, with
- Abstract n.: services

Dim. 2

Dimension 2

Factor Pattern: Dimension 2

Expressive, interactive, speculative discourse with stance marking

Positive Features	Loading
Sum stance to complement clauses	.61033
Verb (not including auxiliary verbs)	.60453
Conditional subordinating conjunction	.58645
Modals of prediction or volition	.58051
Second person pronoun / possessive	.54986
Adjectives in predicative position	.45002
Modals of possibility, permission, and ability	.39717
(First person pronoun / possessive	.36652)
Sum stance that complement clauses controlled by adjectives	.36270

Mean Dim. 2 Scores

Expressive, interactive, speculative discourse with stance marking

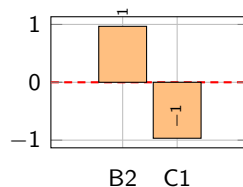
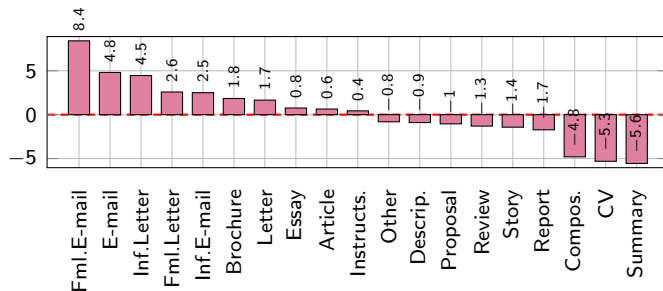


Figure: $R^2=.039800$
(3.98%), $F=20.64$, $p<.0001$

Figure: $R^2=.385718$ (38.57%), $F=16.78$, $p<.0001$

Dim. 3

Dimension 3

Factor Pattern: Dimension 3

Formal, informative, detailed composition

Positive Features	Loading
Type-token ratio	.71462
Word count	.62809
(Word length	.51803)
Adjectives in attributive position	.48521
(Nominalization	.47581)
Cognition nouns	.44334
Abstract nouns	.43417
Sum stance that complement clauses controlled by nouns	.39007
Topical adjectives	.38663

Mean Dim. 3 Scores

Formal, informative, detailed composition

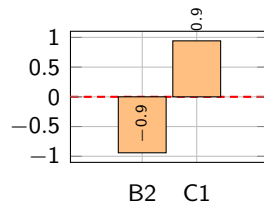
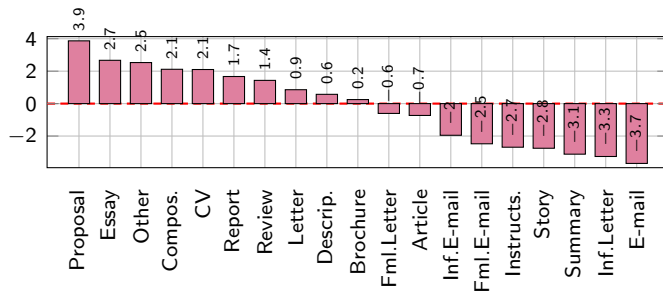


Figure: $R^2=.050658$
(5.07%), $F=26.57$, $p<.0001$

Figure: $R^2=.334427$ (33.44%), $F=13.43$, $p<.0001$

Dim.3 pos

Formal, informative, detailed composition

C1, Proposal, score=13.26

How we could improve our college website. **Introduction.** I am writing this **proposal** to the College Principal in order to outline my suggestions about how we could possibly modify the college website to help **international** students. Reaching the college buildings. I hold the **view that** we should give students worldwide a **better explanation** on how to get to the college facilities, maybe with a well **detailed** map, available in a **wide** range of **foreign languages**. For **information** about the **various** courses, I would suggest the **creation** of a section where everyone could find an **easy-to-read complete** and **concise** schedule that (...)

- Adj.attr.: better, complete, concise, detailed, easy-to-read, foreign, international, various, wide

- Nominaliz.: Introduction, creation, explanation, information, proposal

- Cognitn.n.: information, languages, proposal, view
- Stn.th.cntln.: hold the view that
- Topical adj.: international
- TTR: 31.0 ($\bar{X}$: 28.12)

Dim. 4

Dimension 4

Factor Pattern: Dimension 4

Narrative and descriptive accounts

Positive Features	Loading
Third person pronoun (except it)	.63083
Animate nouns	.55365
that deletion	.45670
that complement clause controlled by verb of likelihood	.42379
Nominal / indefinite pronoun	.41983
that complement clause controlled by factive verb	.33270
that complement clause controlled by non-factive verb	.30041

Mean Dim. 4 Scores

Narrative and descriptive accounts

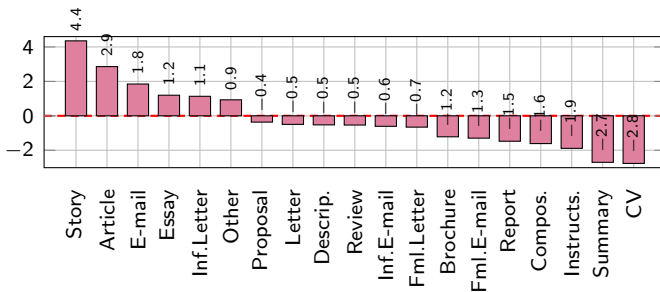


Figure: $R^2 = .195501$ (19.55%), $F = 6.49$, $p < .0001$

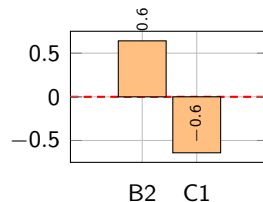


Figure: $R^2 = .025965$ (2.60%), $F = 13.28$, $p < 0.0003$

Dim. 5

Dimension 5

Factor Pattern: Dimension 5

Summarized abstracted overviews

Positive Features	Loading
Adverb within auxiliary (splitting aux-verb)	.65621
Time adverbials	.59119
All passives	.55142
Relational adjectives	.38923

Mean Dim. 5 Scores

Summarized abstracted overviews

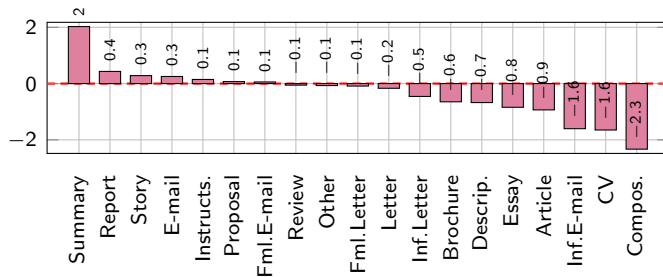


Figure: $R^2=.130339$ (13.03%), $F=4.00$, $p<.0001$

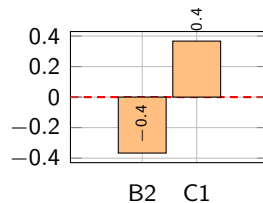


Figure: $R^2=.021480$ (2.15%), $F=10.93$, $p<0.0010$

Dimensions: MD Analysis of coursebooks

- ① Persuasion, speaker engagement, and personal opinion vs Expression of analysis and technical information
- ② Expressive, interactive, speculative discourse with stance marking
- ③ Formal, informative, detailed composition
- ④ Narrative and descriptive accounts
- ⑤ Summarized abstracted overviews

Major rhetorical styles in ELTTs

Subjective	Objective
Persuasive Engaging Expressive	Formal Detailed
Speculative Narrative Descriptive	Analytical Technical

Table: Major rhetorical styles in ELTTs

- 1 **Subjective** style: This style aims to persuade and captivate the reader, employing eloquent, expressive language and engaging techniques to convey the message effectively, by relying on storytelling, anecdotes and character development to establish a connection with the reader.
- 2 **Objective** style: This style aims to present precise information and provide an in-depth view, thorough an examination of the subject matter relying on logical reasoning and a formal tone, thereby emphasizing clarity, precision, and a meticulous approach to conveying information.

Findings

Additive analysis of ICLE on coursebook dimensions

ICLE v.3: Overview

Table: Summary of corpus design

Texts	9,529
Words	5,744,835
Regional components ³	27
Avg. text size	602
Avg. texts per regional component	353

Texts per regional component

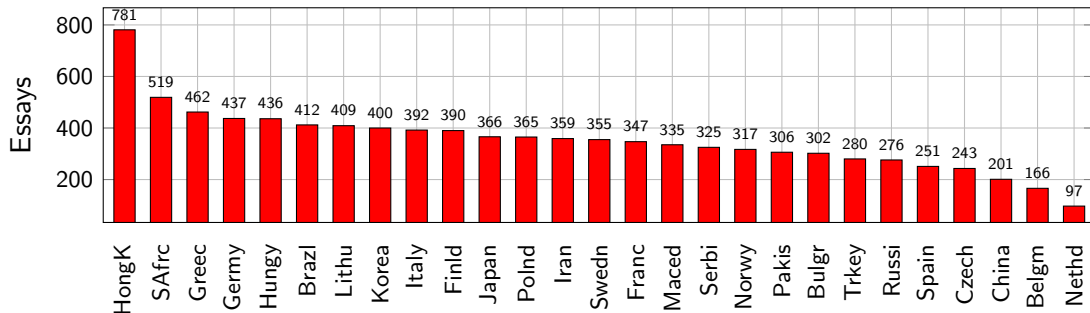


Figure: Size of each regional component

English proficiency level

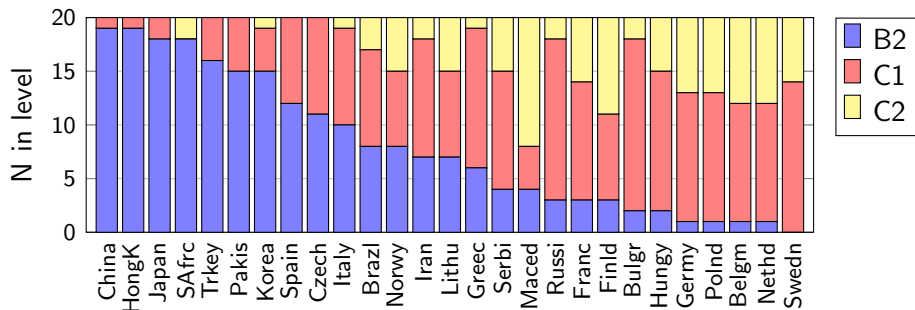
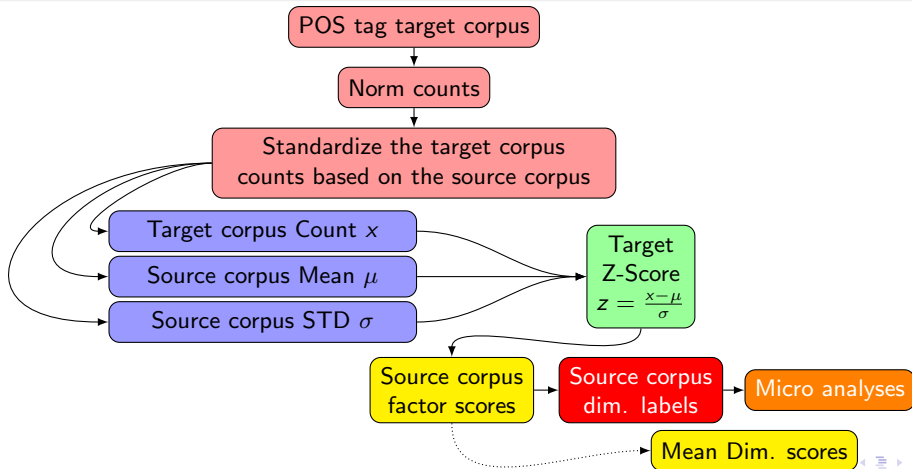


Figure: Proficiency levels (N=20 each subcorpus)

Additive MD Analysis

Berber Sardinha, Veirano Pinto, Mayer, Zuppari, and Kauffmann (2019); Biber and Conrad (2001)



Dim. 1

Dimension 1

Mean Dim. 1 Scores

Persuasion, speaker engagement, and personal opinion vs Expression of analysis and technical information

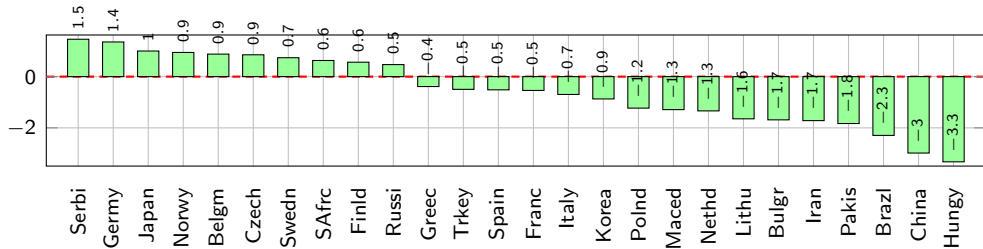


Figure: $R^2=.208111$ (20.81%), $F=99.90$, $p<.0001$

Dim. 2

Dimension 2

Mean Dim. 2 Scores

Expressive, interactive, speculative discourse with stance marking

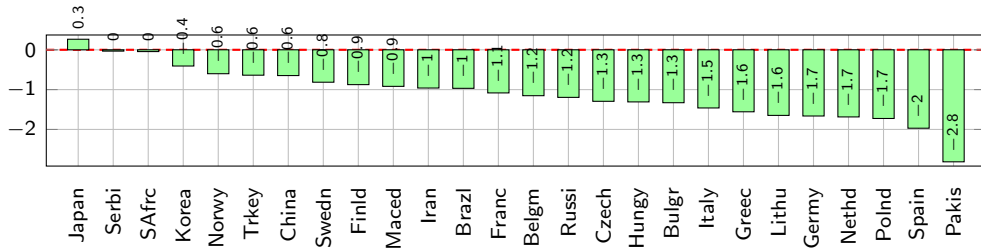


Figure: $R^2=.072654$ (7.27%), $F=29.78$, $p<.0001$

Dim. 3

Dimension 3

Mean Dim. 3 Scores

Formal, informative, detailed composition

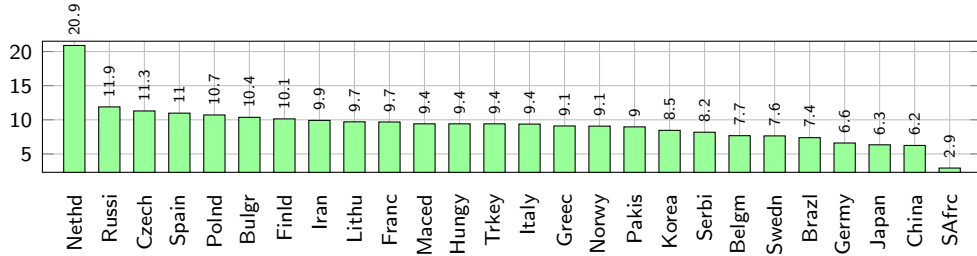


Figure: $R^2 = .273126$ (27.31%), $F = 142.83$, $p < .0001$

Dim. 4

Dimension 4

Mean Dim. 4 Scores

Narrative and descriptive accounts

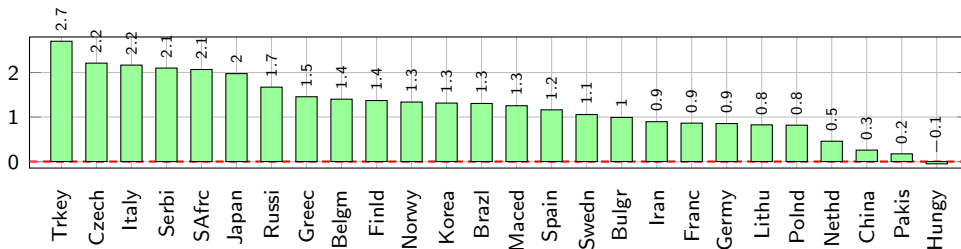


Figure: $R^2 = .068797$ (6.88%), $F = 28.08$, $p < .0001$

Dim. 5

Dimension 5

Mean Dim. 5 Scores

Summarized abstracted overviews

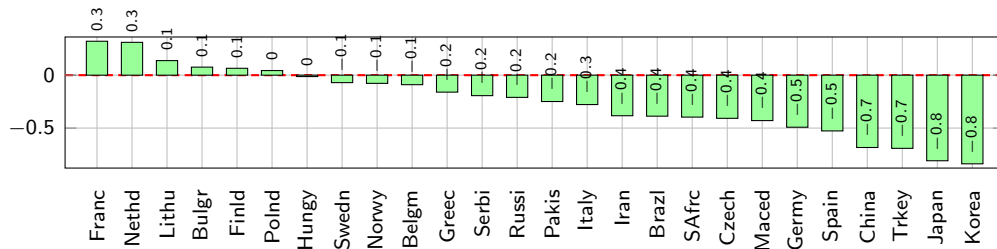


Figure: $R^2=.066130$ (6.61%), $F=26.92$, $p<.0001$

Discussion

Discussion

Additive analysis: Summary

Dim	R^2	Style	Positive pole	Negative pole
3	27.31	Formal, informative	Netherl., Russia, Czech R.	SA, China, Japan
1	20.81	Persuasive vs analytical	Serbia, Germany, Japan	Hungary, China, Brazil

Table: ELTT Dimension that **most distinguish** among the students' compositions

Dim	R^2	Style	Positive pole	Negative pole
2	7.27	NOT Expressive, hypothetical ⁴	–	Pakistan, Spain, Poland ⁵
4	6.88	Narrative, descriptive	Turkey, Czech R., Italy	Hungary, Pakistan, China
5	6.61	NOT Summarized, synoptic ⁶	–	Korea, Japan, Turkey ⁷

Table: ELTT Dimension that **least distinguish** among the students' compositions

⁴Restrained, Factual

⁵Most marked for absence of style

⁶Elaborated, in-depth

⁷Most marked for absence of style

Dim.3 pos

Formal, informative, detailed composition

Netherlands, score=26.58

The purpose of this essay is to gain an insight into the **relationship** between neighbours. The most **important** thing is how to obtain a **good relationship** with neighbours and how to maintain the **good relationship**. Attention will be paid to **desires, expectations**, but to **disappointments** as well, in short the **consequences** of **social** behaviour. **Consequences** which determine the **role** that neighbours give each other. Essentially it is about **fundamental qualities** of **human communication** which determine the **relationship** between neighbours. The question arises whether it is really necessary to use fences to maintain a **good relationship** . Given the **fact that** one has next-door neighbours(...)

- Adj.attr.: fundamental, good, human, important, qualities, social
- Cognitn.n.: communication, consequences, desires, expectations, fact, fundamental, relationship, role

- Stn.th.cntl.n.: the fact that
- Topical adj.: human, social
- TTR: 29.5 ($\bar{X}$: 30.5)

Dim.1 pos

Persuasion, speaker engagement, and personal opinion

Serbia, score=11.29

The question that is **asked** very often, “does age **matter** in a relationship?” **is getting so** boring. A lot of people **say** age **is just** a number, but when **you think** about **it** a little, **is it really?** The truth **is** that a relationship **is** a matter of compatibility and not of numbers. There **are** some advantages and disadvantages in both situations **actually**. They **say** that maturity **is** what **really** matters in a relationship and that **is not far** from the truth. Maturity **is** exactly what **matters** the **most**, then again, **of course, it depends** on what someone is **looking** for (...)

- Stn.adv.: actually, really
- Emphatic: of course, just, most, really, so
- Verb (non-aux.): are, asked, depends, getting, is, looking, matter, say, think

- It: it
- Place adv.: far
- That deletion: people say age is. . .
- Pers.prn.2nd: you

Dim.1 neg

Expression of analysis and technical information

Brazil, score=-12.30

A current issue nowadays **in** Brazil is the structural **reformulation of** universities. Many politicians believe that people who attend **undergraduate** courses are not qualified **to** work immediately. **In addition to** the supposed **underqualification**, Brazil has a few **percentage of** citizens studying at universities. In order to change that, the **government** is imposing a number **of readjustments** that intends to increase the number **of** students **in** Universities and to concentrate studies **in** a practical **level**. Research has once been the **symbol of** Universities **in** Brazil. **Since** the seventies, many private **undergraduate** courses were inaugurated and **research** was not the primary (...)

- Nominaliz.: addition, concentrate, government, percentage, reformulation, undergraduate, underqualification
- Word length: reformulation, readjustments, undergraduate, underqualification

- Prep.: In, Since, in, of, to
- Abstract n.: addition, level, symbol, research, readjustments

Conclusion

Conclusion

Final Remarks

- ① We identified the five main functional dimensions of writing emphasized in ELT text samples.
- ② Based on the similarities and differences across the dimensions, we proposed two major rhetorical styles for ELTs: a subjective style and an objective style.
- ③ Register was the primary driver of variation in ELT language, accounting for up to 33% of the variance.
- ④ Level was comparatively less influential, explaining up to 14% of the variance.
- ⑤ By considering the amount of explained variance and the distinctions among the ICLE subcorpora, we detected a country-specific and a country-independent style
 - The country-specific style consisted of (one or more of these): formal+detailed / persuasive / analytical;
 - The country-independent style comprised (one or more of these): narrative+descriptive / elaborated / reserved+factual;
- ⑥ We hope to have contributed to shed light onto how learner writing aligns with textbook recipes and how textbooks may shape the way students write around the world.

Thank you all for coming!

Obrigado!

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